

From Vigilance to Baseball to Oddfellows: The Needham Family and the Making of Black Civic Power in Philadelphia

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James Needham

James Needham (James Sr.) emerges in historical records during the early 1800s as a freeborn Pennsylvanian who established himself in Philadelphia as a hairdresser. He owned property at 25 Elizabeth Street, a location now occupied by McCall Elementary School.

The Rich Black History of Elizabeth/Barclay Street

Elizabeth Street later became known as Barclay Street in the late 1830s. This area held significant importance in Black Philadelphia's history. The Institute for Colored Youth (ICY) operated its first city location on this street—a high school and college preparatory institute dedicated to training Black teachers. Harlem Renaissance figure Alain Locke's grandfather, Ishmael Locke, taught night school there, which eventually led to ICY's transition to a day school in the 1850s when it relocated to 716-718 Lombard Street.

The Benezet Joint Stock Association, a philanthropic organization led by Jacob C. White Sr., owned property on Barclay Street that was likely rented at reduced rates. The Needham home at 25 Elizabeth Street neighbored a property previously owned by White himself. Both men served as members of the Vigilance Committee, an organization providing immediate support to people escaping enslavement. This proximity suggests a possibility that "the property may have also served as an Underground Railroad safe house and/or a place for people to begin new lives, at affordable rents, after self-emancipating."

James Needham - Institution Builder

James Sr. raised his family at St. Thomas African Episcopal Church, where he served as vestryman and churchwarden. He helped lead the Philadelphia Library Company for Colored People, which operated from the church basement and housed approximately six hundred volumes—a center for Black intellectual life where figures like Robert Purvis and James Forten were active.

His leadership extended across multiple organizations. He served as treasurer of the Vigilance Committee, managing resources for emancipation work. He appeared in the 1838 Civil Rights movement, raising funds to publish the Appeal of the Forty Thousand. During the 1840s, he was a Prince Hall Mason and served on the education committee of the American Moral and Mental Improvement Association, focused on temperance, education, and moral living.

James Sr. co-founded early lodges of the Grand United Order of the Odd Fellows in Philadelphia and the surrounding region.

James Fields Needham

James Fields Needham (James F.), born in 1848, was James Sr.'s son. He entered ICY at eleven or twelve years old, achieving perfect attendance and perfect marks, earning academic prizes. He excelled in mathematics, including algebra and trigonometry, and graduated at fourteen—remarkable given the curriculum's rigor.

Excelling at ICY and Baseball

After graduation, James F. emerged in a new context: baseball. He became secretary of the Excelsior Base Ball Club, a previously undocumented organization. In spring 1867, the Excelsiors won the Colored Baseball Championship against the Brooklyn Uniques, a fact reported in newspapers. The team's lineup included James Brister, a fellow ICY student.

This discovery reveals "there were two Black baseball clubs in Philadelphia, both connected to the Institute for Colored Youth"—the Excelsiors and the better-known Pythians led by Octavius Catto. Baseball historian John Shiffert cautiously suggests the Excelsiors may have applied to the National Association of Baseball Players earlier and been accepted because the association assumed they were white, only realizing later that they were Black and then implementing a blanket exclusion.

This raises the possibility that entry into baseball was "an intentional way to break the color line in white athletic spaces." The question follows: "Can we start thinking of the Institute for Colored Youth as a hotbed of early civil-rights strategy—where education, sport, and public presence were all part of a larger challenge to reshape who belonged in the nation's civic and recreational life?"

After the championship, a public concert was held. At that event, Needham received silk flags and new caps from community women on behalf of the team. At eighteen or nineteen, he was "not the player, not the pitcher—but once again, the secretary,

the representative, the person trusted to stand in public on behalf of an institution."

Civil Service and Civil Rights

After Reconstruction, James Fields Needham became the first Black employee in Philadelphia's tax office, remaining there throughout his career. Simultaneously, he served as treasurer of the Pennsylvania Equal Rights League, a civil rights organization instrumental in desegregating trolley cars and advancing Black male enfranchisement following the 15th Amendment.

A Public Fist Fight

In 1884, James F. was involved in a physical altercation with Gilbert Ball, a prominent Black Republican leader, at a Black political club on Lombard Street (the MS Quay club at 1122 Lombard). The fight apparently stemmed from a disagreement about masonry. Ball struck Needham; charges were filed, and Ball temporarily stepped down as club president before reinstatement.

This incident demonstrates "a Black political world diverse enough to sustain disagreement, rivalry, and public conflict." It complicates the image of Needham as purely respectable, showing him "embedded in civic life deeply enough that disagreement could turn physical—and that, too, is part of human messiness." The authors note that highlighting such contentions prevents historiographical bias from aggregating Black thought without acknowledging nuance and agency.

Social Leadership Manifests in Stone

James Sr. was an early co-founder of the Odd Fellows. By the late 1890s, James F. had become Grand Secretary, playing a central role in building the organization's physical infrastructure.

In Philadelphia, Black physical infrastructure was predominantly churches. Two earlier attempts at halls—Pennsylvania Hall and Beneficial Hall—were destroyed by racist arson. Therefore, townhomes were converted for group use. However, in 1907, the Odd Fellows constructed their own headquarters, which still stands today at 12th and Spruce Streets.

By the turn of the century, the Odd Fellows—headquartered in Philadelphia since 1848—had grown to 155,000 members and more than 3,300 lodges nationwide, making it the largest Black fraternal organization in the country. "The building at 12th and Spruce Streets stands as a highly visible and enduring marker of that collective power. It's still used by the Oddfellows to this day."

Building such a structure required not only financial resources but also the ability to mobilize people. The authors believe "James Fields Needham was that kind of person. We believe that this energy was something passed down through the Needham family: civic responsibility, public presence, and the ability to move community forward."

Moving North

By 1910, James Fields Needham lived near Ninth and Lombard with his wife Medora and daughters Mary and Martha. By 1930, at eighty, he lived at 2256 North 21st Street, reflecting the northward expansion of Philadelphia's Black community beyond its original center at Seventh and Lombard.

James Fields Needham died in 1936 and was buried at Eden Cemetery. "He lived well into the 20th century and is only one generation away from the Underground Railroad work his father was doing before emancipation." The article concludes by noting that his life transformed values into institutions—in baseball, civil service, civil rights organizing, and finally brick and stone—and that Philadelphia's landscape still reflects his contributions.

Images

- James Needham, Image Public Domain — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_ce2bd4ff1358438daea3ce0a071ba0aa~mv2.jpg
- Where Elizabeth Street (Barclay Street) used to be. Torn down in 1910 to build McCall School — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fa2fe46d403d4b1d849adddb3346e7c8~mv2.png
- Where Elizabeth Street (Barclay Street) used to be - from the 1860 Hexamer and Locher map — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e0983fb2b57847cb83c8b8314bf96786~mv2.gif
- From Blacks in Pennsylvania History, 1983. Page 19 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fe34935bb9a54a90a58a02374a76d6a3~mv2.jpg
- Minutes from the Benzet Joint Stock Association show rents for the Barclay Street property — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_791634c1e2fc49cb8b1af6030f29846f~mv2.jpg
- The Needham house was 155 feet east from seventh. 25 Elizabeth became 625 Barclay — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6c14b7a5a8354e9783a9eabb141b4dd6~mv2.png
- Deed showing that the Needham house was neighbors with a home owned by Jacob C. White Sr. — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3268b1041e3845e7895c67e37b454cd0~mv2.jpg
- James Fields Needham in 1907 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_600c803a495f4f88a92166f0861caf24~mv2.png

- 1860 Institute for Colored Youth Report —
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- AI Re-imagining of Excelsior player James Brister —
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- Firsts from ICY Graduates — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_175b1f3775a945529e90f777e06acac7~mv2.png
- This ticket, found in Box 8G of the Leon Gardiner Collection at the Historical Society of Pennsylvania —
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- Concert Article from the Christian Recorder, June 1, 1867 —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_9c3fb2a24a734e278f8da73b7bed5d36~mv2.png
- Gilbert Ball Obituaries from William Dorsey's file —
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- Details of the fight between Ball and Needham —
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- From LaGarrett King's Teaching Black History Framework —
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- Odd Fellows building exterior —
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- Odd Fellows building detail —
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- Sub-Committee of Management and Counsel of the Grand United Order of Odd Fellows (1907-1908) —
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- James Fields Needham's home later in his life - 2256 North 21st Street —
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- James Fields Needham's resting place at Eden Cemetery —
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